

****Quick Bridge:**** If you applied for an internal leadership role and lost to an outside hire, the interview is not where you lost it. Leaders usually know who they want before the posting goes up, based on relationships built long before any role opened. This post shows why being internal is not the same as being known — and what actually builds the kind of cross-functional reputation that gets you tapped before a role ever appears.

Why Internal Candidates Lose to Outside Hires (And How to Make Sure You Are Not One of Them)

Most people know the hidden job market exists. Research consistently shows that 70 to 80 percent of job openings are never publicly advertised. Lou Adler surveyed more than 3,000 LinkedIn members and found that [85 percent of all jobs are filled via networking](<https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/new-survey-reveals-85-all-jobs-filled-via-networking-lou-adler>) — before they are ever posted, before most candidates know to look.

Most people file this away as an external job search problem. They assume it does not apply inside their own company.

It does. And the people who understand that are the ones who get tapped.

When a leadership role opens internally, most of the time the leaders responsible for filling it already know who they want. The posting is a process requirement. The decision happens in the months and years before it. The interview did not start when the role was posted. It started years ago, in every conversation, every cross-team collaboration, every moment someone showed up when they did not have to.

The Internal Promotion Gap Nobody Talks About

LinkedIn's 2024 Workplace Learning Report found that only [1 in 5 employees has confidence in their ability to move internally](<https://learning.linkedin.com/resources/workplace-learning-report-2024>) within their company. That is not primarily a skills gap. It is a visibility gap.

Internal candidates assume the system is merit-based. They believe that tenure plus strong performance reviews will move them forward. Sometimes that is true. More often, the person who gets tapped is the one leadership already knew and trusted before the role was posted.

The frustrating part is that most internal candidates do not find out until after the fact. They came in with the technical background, the company history, the institutional knowledge an outside hire would spend a year building. They did not get it.

The answer is rarely the interview. The answer is who knew them outside their own team — and how well.

Why Being Internal Does Not Make You a Known Quantity

Here is the misread that costs most internal candidates.

They apply for a role in another department and assume that "internal candidate" means "known quantity." You work there. You understand the culture. You have context that no external hire could have on day one.

That is all true. And it only counts inside your own team.

I have worked with people who wanted to transfer into a management role in another department and had never spoken to anyone who worked there. Had never tried to understand what that team actually did. Had never built a relationship with that team's leader or any of its members. And then could not understand why they did not get the role.

[object Object]

The hiring leader does not know how they think under pressure. Does not know how they handle ambiguity or communicate across teams. They know this person by reputation, and that reputation exists in exactly one corner of the organization.

An external hire is a known risk. The gap is visible on paper and you can plan for it. An internal candidate nobody knows outside their own department is a hidden risk. Given a choice, most leaders will go with the person they already trust.

Being internal does not make you a known quantity. Building relationships across the organization makes you a known quantity.

How Technical Leaders Build Cross-Functional Reputation

The leaders who get tapped do not usually know they are being evaluated. They are not running a visibility campaign. They are doing their jobs in a way that naturally crosses team lines.

The pattern is consistent in people who advance without chasing it: they get curious about how other parts of the organization work before they need those relationships. They show up for other teams' problems the way they would want their own team to be shown up for. They step into the problems that nobody owns because those problems do not fit cleanly on any one team's roadmap.

My own career moved forward not when I got good at my job, but when I got curious about how other teams' work connected to mine. I started following my own interest in how things fit together across the organization. I looked for the problems that sat between departments, the ones that fell through the cracks because they did not belong to anyone. Eventually my company built a leadership role around the skill set I had developed.

I did not chase that role. I showed up in the right way long enough that the role found me.

This is not a strategy. It is a habit of engaging with the broader organization before you need anything from it.

There are three behaviors that build this kind of reputation:

****Get curious about adjacent teams before you need them.**** Ask someone you rarely work with to walk you through what their team is focused on this quarter. Do not pitch yourself. Do not try to solve their problems in the first conversation. Just listen and ask follow-up questions. Show up for their work the way you would want them to show up for yours.

****Do the work that crosses boundaries.**** Every organization has important problems that sit between teams. The ones nobody owns because they do not fit cleanly on any one roadmap. The leaders who become known across the organization are the ones who step into those gaps before anyone asks them to. Not to get credit — to solve something that needs solving.

****Show up as a leader in the moments that do not seem to count.**** How you handle a disagreement between two teams. How you treat people who have nothing to offer you right now. These are the moments that build the reputation that travels across an organization. Your manager sees your work every day. The people who will have input on your next role see these moments.

The Technical Visibility Mistakes That Cost Internal Candidates

Most career advice focuses on what to add. Update your profile. Attend more events. Ask for coffee chats. None of that is wrong, but none of it addresses the actual problem.

The visibility mistakes that cost internal candidates are quieter than they appear.

****Staying in your lane too cleanly.**** Excellent work inside your team is not enough if the people outside your team do not know it exists. Organizations are large. The rest of the organization is not watching unless you give them a reason to.

****Waiting to build relationships until you need them.**** The worst time to start building credibility with another team is when you have applied for a role on that team. The relationships that count in hiring decisions were built months or years before any role opened.

****Building visibility with the wrong people.**** You are visible to your direct manager. Your direct manager is not always the person who controls the next role you want. The people who will have input on your next move are often two or three degrees away from your current reporting line.

****Treating cross-functional work as overhead.**** Participating when required, disengaging when optional. The optional moments are exactly where reputation is built or lost. The leaders who advance are the ones who show up as leaders in the rooms where nobody is formally evaluating them.

The internal candidates who get tapped are not doing something elaborate. They have been having real conversations with people across the organization, long before any role was posted. That is the whole thing.

This Week: One Conversation That Does Not Have a Pitch Attached

Identify one team or function you would want to work near eventually. Find one person on that team and ask to understand what they work on. Not to position yourself. Not to start a visibility campaign. Just to learn how another part of the organization works.

That conversation will not get you the next role. But the habit of having it regularly, long before you need anything, is exactly how you become a known quantity somewhere new.

The interview is always happening. Not as pressure. As context.

- Related reading:
- [Professional Relationships Drive Career Growth](<https://blog.jessestaffordcoaching.com>)
- [Your Peers Control Your Success. Here's How to Build Those Relationships.](<https://blog.jessestaffordcoaching.com>)

When did you realize the internal promotion decision had already been made before the posting went up?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help building visibility and influence across your organization, consider reaching out. jessestaffordcoaching.com

****Labels:**** Technical visibility, Peer leadership